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INDIA'S LUXURY INSIDER

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The Last Impression

Why is India an underachiever in the world of design?

Future present

The future of design will be determined by our ability to act locally while thinking globally

Vibhor Sogani, an alumnus of the National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad, is one of India's leading lighting experts. A glimpse of his new studio

Two decades ago, when I graduated from NID, the significance of good design was felt deeply by not only the privileged classes, but also the masses. The notion that design would help to carve a new India was mistakenly, a given.

Today, the situation is much better than what it was back in those days, but it is still far from where it should be. Consider this. The IT sector in India has grown by leaps and bounds in the past two decades and we are the world leaders in this segment. But we rank quite low in the field of design and innovation. One might well ask why. Think about it, is there any product that has been designed in India, which has become a global success? More importantly, has any Indian brand achieved global recognition for its quality, innovation and design? For a country of our size, with ample resources, a young population and a remarkable growth story in many areas, why is there deafening silence when it comes to the world of design?

If we dig deeper into our past, we discover India's great repository of knowledge, her rich heritage, and amazing craftsmanship — qualities that were recognised by all. But today, we can't think of any Indian product or brand that leads in any category across product sectors, be it industry, automobiles, white goods, lifestyle or electronics. Am I being too harsh, too pessimistic, and too critical? Perhaps. But the truth is, given our potential, we are underachievers.

This is worthy of introspection. There are no easy answers, but eventually we can come up with a solution. It may take a while, but to quote Mahatma Gandhi, one can change the world "A step at a time." We need to get onto the right path at the earliest and also stay on course for a reasonable period of time to make a difference. The situation is grim and we have little choice but to take corrective measures. Our global contribution to the design universe is much lesser than it should be. If we turn to hard statistics, especially considering that the general perception is that India is growing rapidly, and is on the verge of beating countries like China in the development stakes, the picture will be quite different. We have to catch up and tune into tomorrow. Policies such as 'Make in India' are a great pointer and steer us in the right direction. IPR, copyrights and such issues have to be supported, encouraged and honoured. A common man should feel pride when he innovates, feeling secure and confident about what he has created.

Studio Vibhor Sogani covers an expanse of 35,000 square feet and is designed into different zones, each highlighting a distinct installation

The challenges one faces in manufacturing, be it prohibitive raw material costs or outdated and expensive labour laws are issues that need to be addressed immediately. The people who can make a difference — those who are in positions of authority and responsibility — will have to take a stand and push development in the right direction. There is no alternative.

It is crucial for the government and its associated agencies to wholeheartedly support innovation, design and development in India

The situation seems to be becoming more favourable, but it is still a far cry from what I would call "an environment which will seduce you to innovate and produce world class products." We have an environment which will encourage failure as much as success. The situation is akin to primary schools, where a child is encouraged to participate, and where finishing a race is more crucial than winning.

It is crucial for the government and its associated agencies to wholeheartedly support innovation, design and development. They need to act as a catalyst. These segments are fast growing and present an opportunity to all. I believe in competition, thus, in the long run, promoting such initiatives will yield great results.

In India, there is no dearth of grassroots innovation. Even in the remotest areas, we often find strange contraptions that have been created by locals to solve their day-to-day problems. Some of them deem fit to be patented. *Jugaad*, a word we hear so often, is an Indian approach to problem solving. It is also indicative of the innovative minds we have. But such latent talent needs to be directed, nurtured and packaged.

There are some encouraging signs. A large number of Indians are very discerning and are conscious about quality and aesthetics. Right now, these Indian customers are dependent on international brands, but at extremely prohibitive prices.

We need to act local but think global. We also need to create our own design vocabulary and identity. At the moment, these have not evolved, but this process will take time. India is transforming and we are witnessing dramatic changes around us. The cityscapes, the architecture, the lifestyles, and even our food are changing rapidly. Global sensibilities and aesthetics have entered our lives, and more importantly, we are becoming comfortable with this change. But simultaneously, we are slowly starting to realise the benefits of our age-old traditions, recipes, and ancient rituals, etc. It is sinking in that while we are racing ahead, we are also losing our rich heritage. This realisation and soul-searching will help us to realign with the future.

Sprouts, a 40 feet high and 150 feet wide creation at the AIIMS flyover is one of Delhi's first site-specific public art

Be it our design aesthetic, our education system or our national pride — all are getting reshaped as we watch. The pride attached to possessing imported goods is still largely visible, but I am optimistic that this euphoria will taper off once we start producing top quality designs and products. Till then, maybe one should live with it, even as we become people who are less forgiving of mediocrity and more demanding. The *chalta hai* attitude has to go.

I am optimistic that we will achieve supremacy, but over a period of time. There are no shortcuts. We will need to toil, but we are a hardworking breed. I just hope and pray that 'innovation' becomes a key word for those who can influence the existing situation, and with time, the 'India' that we dream of, surfaces. »

Nestled in a green patch adjacent to the AIIMS flyover in Delhi is a looming, 40-feet high stainless steel installation that's spread over six acres. The sculpture 'Sprouts' — a public art initiative by the Delhi Government — has been created by **Vibhor Sogani**, one of India's leading creative professionals and product designers.

Jaipur-born Sogani is an alumnus of the National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad. He has carved a niche for himself with his art and light-based installations. He has an experimental style and his design language is dominated by the use of materials such as steel, brass, copper, bronze, stone and mixed media.

Having launched Studio Vibhor Sogani in 1994, the artist recently shifted to new premises in Ghitorni, an expansive space spread over 35,000 square feet. Sogani's repertoire is wide — lifestyle accessories, lighting solutions and offbeat projects such as Mumbai's suburban trains, Kashmiri copper artefacts and even cricket tournament trophies.

The award-winning designer says that India is on the cusp of massive change. He is optimistic that the country will reach the pinnacle of design, while it retains its rich heritage.

Vibhor Sogani
Director, Studio Vibhor Sogani

He believes that introspection and action can help India achieve its design goals.